

and promotion spend, the IPL accounts for a handy 20 per cent.

Kent isn't the only company to have tasted success. In 2018, salt-to-software conglomerate Tata group got involved with the tournament as an associate sponsor through Tata Motors. "IPL was already a big property with access to widespread demographics and geographies. All our brands associated with it—Nexon, Harrier, Altroz and Punch—were successful," says Vivek Srivatsa, Head of Marketing, Sales and Service Strategy at Tata Passenger Electric Mobility. Now, as title sponsor, the group has chosen to promote Tata Neu and Tata Motors. "This is the first time we are using it for an electric version (the Tiago EV)," he says. Launched last September, the Tiago EV performed impressively in terms of bookings, but seemed to have much more potential. This was based on data that indicated that a quarter of the bookings were coming from first-time buyers, with an equal proportion coming from women. Srivatsa says the time had come to give it a big push.

This season of the IPL saw a high-decibel campaign and the results have been heartening—a 3.5x increase in the number of visits to the company's website, while bookings are up 70 per cent since the tournament kicked off. "IPL gives you the reach. One can build a lot of awareness and it is possible to really build on that momentum," he says.

## MEDIA RIGHTS AND MORE

Jayaraj of Viacom18 Sports, meanwhile, says that "there is no plan to charge a subscription fee for sports" on Jio-Cinema. That straightaway puts the onus of generating revenue on advertising. "We have done well on digital advertising during this season of the IPL and believe there is still a very large opportunity. To us, the democratisation of advertisers is a big emerging trend."

Outlining the landscape today, R.C. Venkatesh, Promoter of Lex Sportel Vision and former MD of ESPN Star Sports, says Star could not afford to miss the digital rights for the ICC tournaments after losing those for the IPL and, therefore, went the whole hog—its winning bid of around \$3 billion was on a base price of \$1.44 billion; a few days later, it licensed the television rights to Zee for a reported \$1.5 billion. From a strategic point of view, Viacom18, owned by Mukesh Ambani-led Reliance Industries, is looking to build a digital business across its B2C platforms and the IPL fits in well since it brings in value and a loyal viewership base. That means not looking at IPL from just the perspective of advertising revenue. For Disney, a listed entity in the US, its valuation on Wall Street is today significantly determined by its OTT business—Disney Plus and Disney+ Hotstar.

India is a key market and Disney+ Hotstar, which had the IPL digital rights till last year, is estimated to have got at least 70 per cent of its revenues from cricket. Protecting its subscriber base is, therefore, an imperative for Disney Star.

Rajesh Kaul, Head of Sports at Sony Pictures Networks India, says subscriptions have driven sports in larger markets, whereas in India it is a combination of that and advertising. India, he says, has over 300 million households with television penetration close to 70 per cent. "As this number increases in rural areas, it will bring newer viewers into cricket. Plus, sports gets around 40 per cent of viewership from women and that, too, can take off with how our teams are doing across formats."

Then there are those who own IPL teams. They have invested huge sums to buy and promote them. Their revenue comes from a combination of the central pool of media rights, stadium collections and sponsorship, to name a few key sources. Rajesh V. Menon, VP & Head of Royal Challengers Bangalore, says that though the IPL is a two-month tournament, his company works through the year. "We want to build a lifestyle proposition and are not restricted to a particular region. The RCB brand has now extended into a deal with Puma for athleisure,



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**VIVEK SRIVATSA**  
Head of Marketing,  
Sales and Service  
Strategy, Tata  
Passenger Electric  
Mobility



ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA